

**UNIT
5**

MODAL VERBS

UNIT 5 MODAL VERBS

We use modal verbs to express: ability, advice, logical conclusion, necessity, offers, obligation/duty, permission, possibility, probability, prohibition, requests **or** suggestions

- **The modal verbs are:** can, could, may, might, must, ought to, will, would, shall, **and** should.
- **They do not take -s in the third person singular.**
He **can ride** fast.
- **They come before the subject in questions and are followed by 'not' in negations.**
Could I leave now?
I'm afraid you **can't** leave.
- **The modal verbs are followed by an infinitive without to except for 'ought to'.**
She **could leave** early but she really **ought to stay** till the end.
- **Each modal verb normally has more than one use.**
Shall I help you with the dishes? (offer) **Shall** we go out tonight? (suggestion)
- **Certain verbs or expressions have virtually the same meaning as some modals. These are:**
need (= must), had better (= should), have to/have got to (= must), be able to (= can), used to (= would), etc.
I **have to** hurry to catch the bus. (= the situation is making it necessary to do so.)

Functions of Modal Verbs and Synonymous Expressions

Use	Present/Future	Past
Ability	can, is/am/are able to	could, was/were able to
Possibility	may, is/am/are likely to, perhaps or maybe	may have + verb 3rd form or perhaps, maybe + present perfect/ past simple
Probability	might	might have + verb 3rd form

Certainty	must / will	
Advisability	should, ought to (stronger than should) (escapable), must (inescapable)	
Logical assumption	must	must have + verb 3rd form
Permission	can/could/may/might	was/were allowed to

"Can" for Ability	Structure	Examples
Affirmative	Subject + can + Verb (base form) + Object	I can swim.
Negative	Subject + cannot / can't + Verb (base form) + Object	I can't swim.
Question	Can + Subject + Verb (base form) + Object?	Can you swim?
Negative Question	Can't + Subject + Verb (base form) + Object?	Can't you swim?
"Could" for Ability	Structure	Examples
Affirmative	Subject + could + base verb	I could swim when I was 5 years old
Negative	Subject + could not (couldn't) + base verb	She couldn't speak English when she was younger.
Question	Could + subject + base verb?	Could you ride a bicycle when you were a child?
Negative Question	Could + subject + not (couldn't) + base verb?	Couldn't he read when he was 4?
"Should" for Advice	Structure	Examples
Affirmative	Subject + should + base verb	You should eat more vegetables for a healthy diet.
Negative	Subject + should not (shouldn't) + base verb	You shouldn't skip your homework.
Question	Should + subject + base verb?	Should we go to the park this afternoon?
Negative Question	Should + subject + not (shouldn't) + base verb?	Shouldn't I call my friend now?

EXERCISES

Exercise: 1

Fill in the blanks with **can**.

1. I _____ ride a bicycle.
2. We _____ see the stars at night.
3. Ahmed _____ speak three languages!
4. My little sister _____ tie her shoelaces now.
5. _____ you help me with this question?

Exercise: 2

Fill in the blanks with **could**.

1. When I was younger, I _____ run very fast.
2. She _____ not come to the party yesterday.
3. _____ you hear the thunder last night?
4. My grandfather _____ read without glasses when he was my age.
5. We _____ see the mountains from our hotel window.

Exercise: 3

Fill in the blanks with **May**.

1. _____ I go to the washroom, please?
2. You _____ leave after you finish your work.
3. The teacher said we _____ use colours for our project.
4. _____ I borrow your pencil for a moment?
5. It _____ rain today, so carry an umbrella.

Exercise: 4

Fill in the blanks with **might**.

1. He _____ come to the match if he finishes his homework.
2. We _____ go to the zoo this weekend.
3. It _____ snow in Murree next month.
4. I _____ not be able to join the trip.
5. She _____ win the race if she runs fast.

Exercise: 5

Fill in the blanks with "can," "may," or "be allowed to" in the correct form.

1. Students _____ use their phones during the exam. (not permitted)
2. _____ I open the window? It's getting a bit stuffy here. (asking permission)
3. Visitors _____ take pictures in the museum only in certain areas. (permitted)
4. You _____ park here without a permit. (not allowed)
5. _____ we leave early if we finish our work on time? (asking for approval)
6. Employees _____ request a flexible schedule under certain conditions. (permitted by rules)

Exercise: 6

Rewrite the sentences using "can," "may," or "be (is/am/are) allowed to" as appropriate.

1. It's forbidden to smoke in this area.

People _____.

2. Is it permitted for students to use the library on weekends?

_____ the library on weekends?

3. Taking pictures inside the gallery is prohibited.

Visitors _____.

4. I am asking for permission to leave early.

_____ early?

5. Rules state that pets are not permitted in the apartment.

Residents _____.

Exercise: 7

Choose the correct option.

1. _____ I use your laptop for a minute?

a) May **b)** Am I allowed to **c)** Can

2. Employees _____ take breaks at specific times.

a) May not **b)** Aren't allowed to **c)** Can't

3. _____ we take drinks into the cinema?

a) Can **b)** May **c)** Are we allowed to

4. Students _____ use the lab without a supervisor present.

a) Are allowed to **b)** Can't **c)** May

5. _____ I borrow your book?

a) May

b) Can

c) Am I allowed to

Exercise: 8

Write your own sentences.

1. Write two sentences using "can" to show permission or prohibition.

a) _____.

b) _____.

2. Write two sentences using "may" to ask for permission.

a) _____.

b) _____.

3. Write two sentences using "be allowed to" in the past tense.

a) _____.

b) _____.

Ability

Can (is/am/are able to)

Could – (was/were able to)

- **Can** expresses ability in the present and future. **Could** expresses ability in the past. The verb **can** is used only in the present or future and **could** in the past. We use **be able to** to form all the other tenses.

He **could** climb up mountains before he had an accident.

He **can't** climb mountains now but he **had been able to** do so before he had an accident.

- **Was/were able to (= managed to)** is used to express ability in the past for either single or repeated actions.

He **was able to** reach home before midnight. (single action)
(**NOT:** could)

- **Could** is used in statements to express general ability in the past for repeated actions.

She **could/was able to** read when she was four. (**could/was able to** are both correct)

- However, with **feel, hear, see, smell, understand, etc.** we normally use **could** for single actions.

I **could** hear a noise coming from the dining room. (single action) (**NOT:** was able to)

- **Could/was, were able to** are both used in negations and questions for either single or repeated actions.

They **weren't able to/couldn't** win the race. (single action)

Could you/Were you able to drive a car when you were fifteen?
(repeated action – general ability in the past).

Exercise: 10

Fill in with these options: (can, can't, could, couldn't, was able to, wasn't able to, had been able to)

1. He could/was able to run much faster when he was younger.
2. On entering the house, she _____ smell something burning in the kitchen.
3. I'm busy today, so I _____ go shopping with you.
4. I heard Sami's voice, but I _____ see him until I turned on the lights.
5. When I lived on the coast, I _____ swim in the sea every day.
6. I'm not usually very good at tennis, but yesterday I _____ beat my brother in a match.
7. He _____ fix the tap, so he called a plumber.
8. I had my hands full, so I _____ open the door.
9. Sarah is very clever. She _____ speak four languages.

Exercise: 11

Select the correct form of "can," "could," "was / were able to," or "had been able to" to complete each sentence.

1. When I was in school, I _____ solve complex math problems easily.
a) can **b)** could **c)** was able to
2. Despite the heavy rain, the firefighters _____ put out the fire in time.
a) were able to **b)** could **c)** had been able to

3. I _____ finish the project on time, even though I started it late.

a) could

b) can

c) was able to

4. Last summer, we _____ hear the sound of waves from our beach house every morning.

a) could

b) had been able to

c) were able to

5. She _____ drive a car when she was just sixteen years old.

a) can

b) could

c) had been able to

Exercise: 12

Rewrite the sentences correctly by replacing the incorrect usage of "can," "could," "was/were able to," or "had been able to."

1. He could win the marathon yesterday.

_____.

2. I can hear a strange noise in the middle of the night yesterday.

_____.

3. After a lot of practice, I could finally play the piano well last week.

_____.

4. They weren't able to climb the mountain last year because they could fall ill.

_____.

5. She had been able to understand Spanish when she moved to Mexico last month.

_____.

Exercise: 13

Fill in the blanks with "can," "can't," "could," "couldn't," "was/were able to," or "had been able to."

1. When I was a child, I _____ ride a bike without any help.
2. The power was out, so I _____ cook dinner last night.
3. She _____ run a marathon after months of training and dedication.
4. If we leave early tomorrow, we _____ catch the first train.
5. Despite the distractions, I _____ concentrate on my studies last week.
6. They _____ hear the music playing from the other side of the street.
7. He _____ find his lost wallet after searching everywhere.
8. My grandparents _____ speak German fluently when they lived in Europe.

Must – Have to – Have got to (Necessity – Obligation)

- **Must** (= it's necessary; I'm obliged to) **is used when the speaker decides what is necessary to do.**
I **must** buy some new clothes. (I say so. I decide what to do.)
- **Have to** (= it's necessary) **is used when the necessity comes from outside the speaker or when others decide for the speaker what is necessary to do.**
He **has to be** at work at 9.00. (The boss says so.)
- **Have got to** has the same meaning as have to but is used in spoken English.
Mum, I've **got to go to** the library.

I **must** meet Sofia tonight. (It's very urgent that I meet her.)
I **have to** meet Sofia tonight. (I need to meet her.)

- **Must is used only in the present or future. I must** go to the meeting tomorrow. **It borrows the rest of its tenses from have to.** She **had to** be present at the lecture last Monday.

Exercise: 14

Fill in the blanks with must or have to.

Sami: Hi, Zain. Why weren't you at the meeting this morning?

Zain: I had a doctor's appointment. So, what did I miss?

Sami: Well, Mr. Ali, the new factory owner, said that we 1)

have to wear overalls at all times. Also, he wants us to arrive at 8 am and we 2) _____ clock in.

Zain: What about overtime?

Sami: There is a possibility of working overtime but you 3) _____ decide whether you want to work extra hours.

Zain: Did he say anything about break times? I hope we don't 4) _____ clock in and out every time we have a break.

Sami: No, we don't, but Mr. Ali insists that we 5) _____ have fifteen-minute breaks every three or four hours. Like before, we 6) _____ choose when we would like to take those breaks.

Zain: I see. And did he say anything about the parking? I think it's terrible that the company says we 7) _____ use the public car park. It's too far away.

Sami: I 8) _____ say I agree with you, Zain, but he didn't say anything. We 9) _____ bring it to the attention of the personnel department sometime.

Mustn't – Needn't (Prohibition – Absence of Necessity)

- **Mustn't (it's forbidden)**. You **mustn't** get off the bus before it stops.
- **Needn't/Don't have to (it isn't necessary)**. Today is a holiday – you **needn't/don't have to** go to work.

Exercise: 15

Underline the correct item.

Snorkeling Information and safety tips

1. You mustn't/needn't go snorkelling alone.
2. You **mustn't/don't have to** be an athlete to go snorkelling.
3. You **don't have to/mustn't** go snorkelling in dangerous waters.
4. You **needn't/mustn't** buy your own equipment. You can rent it.
5. You **needn't/mustn't** harm the wildlife when you go snorkelling.
6. You **mustn't/don't have to** wear equipment that doesn't fit properly.

Exercise: 16

Complete the sentences with **mustn't**, **needn't**, or **don't have to**.

1. You _____ bring food into the library; it's against the rules.
2. It's Saturday, so you _____ wake up early if you don't want to.
3. Students _____ cheat during exams; it's strictly prohibited.
4. We _____ buy tickets for the movie in advance. There's plenty of space in the theater.
5. Drivers _____ park their cars in front of fire hydrants.
6. You _____ bring your laptop to the meeting; it's optional.

Exercise: 17

Rewrite the sentences with mustn't, needn't, or don't have to.

1. It's against the rules to use your phone during the test.

_____.

2. There's no need to wash the dishes; I'll do it later.

_____.

3. It's not necessary for you to attend the meeting tomorrow.

_____.

4. People are forbidden to smoke inside the hospital.

_____.

5. There's no requirement to bring formal clothes for the trip.

_____.

Exercise: 18

Match the situations with the correct rule by writing A for mustn't (forbidden) and B for needn't or don't have to (not necessary).

1. You _____ go to work on a public holiday.

2. You _____ bring glass bottles to the beach;
it's against the law.

3. You _____ wear a suit for the casual event.

4. Visitors _____ touch the paintings in the
museum.

5. You _____ carry your own tools to the
workshop; they will be provided.

6. You _____ enter the construction site
without safety gear.

Needn't – Didn't need to – Needn't have (Absence of necessity)

- **Don't have to/Don't need to/Needn't + bare infinitive** (it is not necessary to do sth in the present or future).
You **don't have to/don't need to/needn't worry** about it any more. I'll take care of that. (It is not necessary to worry.)
- **Didn't need to/Didn't have to + bare infinitive** (It was not necessary in the past and we knew about it).
She didn't need to/**didn't have to buy** a dress for the party. (The action was clearly unnecessary at the time but it was done.)
- **Needn't + bare perfect infinitive** (We know that something happened in the past although it was not necessary.)
You **needn't have said** that she already knew my name. (you said so, but you now realized it was unnecessary.)

Exercise: 19

Fill in the gaps with: needn't have, didn't need to and the correct form of the verb in brackets.

1. Sami _____ (buy) the new shoes. He already had a pair that was in perfect condition.
2. Ali _____ (bring) his umbrella. It wasn't raining at all.
3. Sarah _____ (work) so hard last night. The project was already finished.
4. Sofia _____ (call) me. I was already on my way.
5. Sami _____ (prepare) a speech. Everyone was just having a casual discussion.
6. Ali _____ (buy) those extra snacks for the party. We already had enough.

Exercise: 20

Fill in the gaps with **mustn't** or **needn't**/**don't have to**.



- **Mustn't** = **Not allowed** to do something.
- **Needn't** = **Not necessary** to do something.
- **Don't have to** = **Not required** to do something

1. **A:** Shall I help you clean the car?

B: No, thanks. Sami needn't help me. I can do it myself.

2. **A:** Tell Ali and Sarah that they _____ drive us to the party. Sofia has offered to take us.

B: No problem. I'll tell them tonight when I see them.

3. **A:** You _____ touch the statues in the museum.

B: I know. It's forbidden.

4. **A:** Tell Sofia that she _____ forget to pay the electricity bill today.

B: OK. I will.

5. **A:** Sarah _____ be late for her appointment tomorrow morning.

B: Don't worry. She won't.

6. **A:** I'm going to the shops. Do you want anything?

B: No. You _____ get me anything. I've just been.

Exercise: 21

Complete the sentences with the correct form of **needn't have** or **didn't need to** and the verb in brackets.

1. I _____ (book) a table at the restaurant because it wasn't crowded at all.

2. She _____ (apologize) so much for being late; everyone

understood the situation.

3. We _____ (bring) a jacket since the weather turned out to be warm and sunny.

4. He _____ (worry) about the interview as it was postponed to next week.

5. You _____ (clean) the kitchen; the cleaners were scheduled to come that morning.

Exercise: 22

Underline the correct form (needn't have or didn't need to) to complete the sentences.



- **Needn't have** = The action was done, but it wasn't needed.
- **Didn't need to** = It wasn't necessary to do the action, but we don't know if it was done or not.

1. They _____ (needn't have/didn't need to) bought tickets for the concert; their friends had already gotten them for free.

2. We _____ (needn't have/didn't need to) wake up early yesterday because the meeting was canceled.

3. He _____ (needn't have/didn't need to) left so soon; the party continued for hours after he went home.

4. She _____ (needn't have/didn't need to) carry the heavy boxes herself because help was available.

5. The children _____ (needn't have/didn't need to) wear their uniforms because it was a casual dress day at school.

Exercise: 23

Rewrite the sentences using the correct form of needn't have or didn't need to to show absence of necessity in the past.

1. It wasn't necessary for me to buy groceries because the fridge was full.

I _____.

2. He locked the doors, even though I had already done it.

He _____.

3. We brought umbrellas, but it didn't rain at all.

We _____.

4. Sarah didn't have to attend the meeting as it was cancelled, but she went anyway.

Sarah _____.

5. They spent extra money on decorations, even though it wasn't required.

They _____.